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Cascadú

Cascadú is a celebrated African percussionist and has performed frequently in New York City and in his native country of Trinidad. He has recorded with such notable artists as Jon Lucien, Jimmy Owens, and T.K. Blue. His solo recordings include "Caribbean Odyssey," a collection of original pieces that are unmistakably Caribé.

Cascadú was interviewed in Clinton, New York on November 15, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

C: Thank you for doing this, Monk.

MR: Well it's a pleasure.

C: And thank you for getting us here, because I traveled the entire route with Marissa. This was part of a completely shared vision between the two of us to get — and when she told me of your input, you know, throughout the entire week of this process, I was like this is a very special man, so I just want to thank you from the bottom of my heart.

MR: It's all selfish on my part.

C: And I believe you.

MR: I mean, well, I want to talk about you and your band mates, the thing you did yesterday was — when I asked a question I said, "My head is spinning." And it was really true. Because there's something about, this is not a question but rather an observation and maybe you can talk about it. There's something about this percussion rhythms and things that you gentlemen played that reaches so deep into you — I don't know what it is, but — like if you were in New York City and you were walking and all of a sudden you heard this and you could tell well that's live drum music, like you would go there. It's like a magnet or something. What is that about?

C: I think the drum has the ability to reach deeply into your soul. That's the power of that vibrating membrane and that piece of wood. It has the power to call you. And there's something spiritually that we respond to, that people respond to, just like you're saying you know. You hear these drums and there's something that you want to go and visit it. You want to be in the presence of that. And I think it's a very primal call to the deepest part of our being. Because we're all connected to that somehow or the other you know. I mean philosophically okay you know this is a membrane, a form, you know there's a membrane vibrating here. We come through a membrane into life you know. That, it is a membrane that beats in the womb. We are surrounded by that membrane. So somehow or the other we are connected both biologically, from the time of our creation, the time of intention to this membrane of some kind of link, some kind of spiritual link from where we came from. And the drum has access, or the drum reminds us of that connection, of

that place where we come from. Monk, I've seen, in Trinidad, there are people, and we have a very, very strong drum culture in Trinidad. And I have been to concerts in these big halls, You know people come in all — their suits, all suited up, and we come, we are a British colony for over 150 years, a Spanish colony for over 300 years etcetera. You know? And you know people will speak and dress in a very European way. And that drum would play in that concert hall. And people would start to, you know, dressed up in their fine fancy you know. And there's something very, very primal that we relate to with the drum. And those of us who play and who dedicate our lives to this, like I was talking about people like Don Alias and Emile Latimer who were amazing inspirations for me, Montego Joe, Chief Bey, all these guys, man, who were like the forerunners, and then in Trinidad there was a drummer by the name of Andrew Beddoe. I mean when he played you were transported to another place altogether. In Haiti Tiroro, man this guy, the talking about Tiroro is that his hands were a phenomenon. And what he did with his hands could not be consciously analyzed at all. What came out of the meeting between his hands and the skin was from another world altogether, and it was he, Tiroro, was one of the guys who inspired Don Alias as well as Emile Latimer because Emile always taught me, Emile always said to me man you really want to listen to the drummer, if you really want to play, go check out Tiroro. You know? Check out his music. So I think that aspect of playing percussion, of being close to sounds that come from nature — because that's what we do. We color the music with, you know, with membranes, with pods, with seeds, with conch horns you know, with animal horns and shells and all. That's what we do. We're very organic. So the entire percussive world as we know it, traditionally, right — and what do the shamans use when they are trying to heal people and go into that spiritual realm? They use seeds. They use the membrane of an animal. The Native Americans used the drum you know [scats]. Right? I mean the rattle you know, the maraca or the rattle or the shaker or whatever you call it, all of these instruments help us to transcend the physical and access the metaphysical. Help us to leave the mundane and get to the spiritual. So when — you are absolutely right — what is this thing that makes you — that draws you in? It's because something is happening that causes you to deeply, spiritually, to come and be present.

MR: I didn't even introduce you on film. This is Cascadú. And I can't imagine that you ever play a gig where you are coasting. And by that I mean those of us who play gigs all the time, sometimes you're playing and you know it's just, you're looking at your watch and oh man it's only 8:15 and — when I was watching the three of you yesterday it's hard for me to imagine that you would do that.

C: It doesn't even exist in our timeframe. There's no timeframe for us. And we could have just gone on and gone on and gone on and gone on you know. But it doesn't, because I

mean you live it. For me, and I know, this is all Chembo does you know. I've done a number of other things in my life, but to be doing this now as pretty much the only thing that I do, I consider myself to be very, very fortunate to have some physical health at this stage of my life, and to have the freedom to be able to live my passion now, I mean, for whatever time I have left this is it, and there's no time on the clock you know. There's no limitation to what can happen next.

MR: That makes me smile because I think all the dues you paid in your other professions, even if you liked it — you know some people go through life and they have a job they don't like and they just can't wait to be retired and do something they like. It sounds — I'm just guessing that you liked the other things you did but now that you're doing this it makes it all that much more fruitful for you.

C: Absolutely. Absolutely. Well I started, you know as I mentioned, I am from Trinidad. And I grew up in a folk culture. I was first a dancer. I started dancing at age five and went through until I was about fifteen, sixteen years old, dancing. All my life I was close to the drum. I remember where we lived in Fyzabad, which is deep south Trinidad. A lot of roots, a lot of culture. There was a shango yard not too far away up on the hill, and I used to hear the drums coming across at night when I was you know, about to go to sleep. And they were in ceremony and everything. I remember this having a very, very profound effect on my psyche much later on of course. Because you're up at night and you're hearing these drums. And then you go and you're performing and you're dancing and stuff and you're part of the tradition and part of this, and this is what you're dancing. You know you're dancing to shango, you're dancing the Trinidad folk culture, you're dancing pique, and bellaire and bongo and joropo and all kinds of stuff that was going on. And so much later on, much later on, when I was not dancing anymore, that energy had to find a way out and it just went to the music. And at sixteen years old it stopped for me. I had a really bad accident. I broke my neck, I was hit by a car, by a van, and broke my neck. So my dance, my aspirations for a dance life ended. It wasn't a final thing but the level of performance for me at that point in time, I just was not able to keep, so I moved on, and that energy came out in the music. I dedicated myself to the music. And all throughout university, all throughout my other jobs and everything else, when I finished university, it was at university that I actually started to take the music to a whole other level because I was the first of my family to go abroad to study. I have three brothers, I'm the second. My oldest brother is all art and music. Me: I am a cross between the art and the sciences. At least that's how I live my life. The brother after me was physics and the baby of the family got his Ph.D. at 27 years old and he leads the field today in genetic material that causes epilepsy in human beings, right? So he had his own lab at Emory and everything else. So for me, for me, all throughout my life I always had this duality. And it was a

constant struggle between the sciences and the arts. The sciences and the arts. When I went to university, and I went to university to study biogeography because I wanted to do forestry and ecology and stuff. At York University there was a Caribbean performing group on the campus. And I figured since nobody here knew me I would try and, you know, see if I could get back to a little bit of dance. And it so happened that the guy who was leading that knew of my performances in Trinidad because he had seen me perform with one of the biggest dance companies and all that type of stuff, knew that I was close to the drum. And a buddy of mine who was there encouraged me to start playing percussion. I used to play guitar, I had played trumpet, I had done all kinds of other things. And this thing started to get me deeper into myself, the whole realm of percussion, being introduced to the congas, not from the folk drum perspective of what we do in Trinidad and everything, which is commonplace and sacred in its own right, but to actually dedicate some time while my head was in academic mode, to consciously undertake the study of percussion. Go to class and do orchestral percussion and read pieces by these contemporary composers for percussion and everything hand claps and you know, all that type of stuff and everything else. It made a world of a difference. And as I started going deeper and deeper I started finding myself more and more and more and more. And I was a lost Caribbean son in a sea of Toronto. And I had never experienced winter before. I had never been among so many people who did not look like me before. It was culture shock, it was everything, and I was really trying to find myself. And I think this really brought me around. And throughout the rest of my university life I continued playing music. When I returned to Trinidad and I started working as a marine biologist, a marine research biologist, I had the opportunity to continue to play music because I was one of the — probably one of the few percussionists or may be the first even, to return to Trinidad having studied outside and having had the influence of the breadth of jazz and playing out and you know, working as a percussionist with stuff hanging all over you and having had the experience to see guys like Don and, you know, to study with Emile Latimer and everything else. When I got back to Trinidad I was one of the first call percussionists for visiting bands that was coming in, and I hooked up with some of the top players in Trinidad, guys like Len Boogsle Sharpe and Raf Robertson Clive Zanda — all those guys come from the calypso jazz tradition. And I just plugged right in. When I left and I came here, came out to live in New York, all I wanted to do was to play music. I didn't want to do anything else. But I didn't have any means to make a living you know. Because in Trinidad you know, your entire support system is there, you might be a big fish in a little pond. You get to New York and there are guys going [scats] all around you, you know what I mean? So I had to go back to study.

MR: So in Trinidad you were holding down a day gig?

C: I was doing as much as a marine research biologist as I was doing as a musician. My life was completely split between music and a full time research appointed job for which I got United Nations fellowships to travel and study. My specialty was in sea floor ecology.

MR: Was the spirituality that you talked about yesterday that's connected to this percussive music, was that spirituality a part of your life at that point?

C: Yes, yes. My desire to leave Trinidad and follow the path of the drum was actually prompted by my ancestral awakenings. They are the ones who told me you must leave Trinidad. You cannot do what you have to do here. You must leave and you must follow the sound of the drum. Monk, I left one of the biggest paying jobs for a young scientist. I left one of the highest paying seats in the music world in our small island. I packed my bags. My parents thought that I was crazy. "Son, where are you going?" "I'm going to New York." "What you gonna do?" "I don't know but I want to play music." "How are you gonna live?" "I don't know but I will find a way." I left the island on May 15, 1984. It was a full moon. To be in New York on May 16, which was my birthday. I would turn 27 I believe, to start a new life. And that's how I came. I came — I had to jump. I had to jump and I had to find my wings. And if this spiritual calling was going to be as great as I had experienced it in my time in Trinidad and growing up etcetera, then I knew that it would provide me with the wings and the courage and the sustenance to be able to do what I had to do.

MR: I'm not sure if I can phrase this question correctly but if you had this spiritual calling, would there have been another way to pursue that call without being a percussionist? In order words could you have become a priest within that religion as opposed to following the percussion path?

C: I am sure. I'm sure there are people who have done it. But for me and for everybody the path is different. Right? For me it really happened in my relationship with the drum. So, and interestingly the drum that I was hearing, which I didn't know, was batá. And I remember specifically when I went to, when I left Trinidad I went straight to Emile Latimer in Buffalo. Emile had set up a room in his house for me, I mean decorated with Africanisms all around. Listen, I came to Emile, I stayed with Emile for a month until — and Emile was not the kind of person who would sit you down and teach you, "Now the left hand is what's doing this and the right hand is what's doing this." No. Emile was about being a drummer is a life experience. This is what you do because this is your soul. Emile didn't sit down and practice. No. Emile lived that drum every single day. So every day we would get up, we would have breakfast, we would do meditation, etcetera, and we went out to work as drummers. And he carried me to every gig. Everything that he was doing, whether he was playing for dance class, whether he was playing for kids, whether

he was leading a drum circle, whether he had a gig that night at the club, etcetera. I was attached to Emile's drums. Drum in tow and we went. And I left there a month later after I had had a vision and a dream that there was this entire, this entire lineage of drummers that I was supposed to come into contact with on my path. And I saw them all, Monk, I saw every single one of them in the dream, who I would have to connect with. And I told Emile, I got up and I told Emile about the dream. And Emile said, "Brother, it's time for you to go. You've got to get to those people." And I left. I left, and from Emile I went to New York. And I had, I went to take a lesson at Drummers' Collective in New York. And the lesson I had — I didn't even know who the guy was. His name was Frankie Malabe, one of the, at the time one of the greatest congeros. Amazing, amazing conga, batá, percussion player. And I'm sitting down there with Frankie, the drums between us, Frankie is like sitting where you are, I'm sitting here, and there's just drums between us etcetera, right? And before Frankie does anything, Frankie says to me, "What is it that you're looking for?" He says, "Because you're on a mission. You are on a spiritual mission." This is how I connected with Frankie. And I said, I was shaking because I had never sat in the presence of someone who told me something about what came deeply into my consciousness, you know, as part of my journey. And so Frankie says, you know, "You have to study this drum." He says, "We're going to start here but I am doing a gig this weekend and I want you to come." So I told him, I told him, I said, "I have to follow the sound of batá." He says, "Come to the gig." I go to this gig and it is the first time I am in the presence of batá players, right? Full on ceremonial dancing, and everything, it's at the McBurney Y on 23rd Street in New York etcetera, it's a performance, right? But the dancers are ceremonially dressed and everything else. I mean I had had experiences in Trinidad, but this was different, right? I'm in a different headspace now. And Frankie introduces me to another, to the gentleman who had actually put on the entire performance, right? I got introduced and of course I'm wowed by the batá and everything else, completely, completely, completely. The dancers, you know, Elegbara, Yemonja, with the divinities of dancing and everything else. And I get introduced to this gentleman and I told him that I'm being in New York and I want to study. I'm looking for a teacher. So he says, "Well you know, come over to my studio," you know, on Monday, etcetera. I go over to his studio and I'm sitting down and we're sitting down and again, Monk, like where you are sitting, and there is drums between us, right? And I'm here. And I'm getting ready and I'm looking down at the drums and then I look up. And I see this guy's face as one of the guys that I saw in my dream. And I shouted out, "Stop! Stop! Stop! Don't move." I'm freaking out, right? I'm completely freaked out at this point in time. I'm like sitting there, and I'm like don't move. Tears are welling up, my whole face has gone, I'm in this other place altogether. Right? And I'm sitting there and I'm like "Don't

move. Don't move." And tears are running down my face. And I said, "It's you! It's you, it's you." And I'm talking. "You, I saw you in my dream. I saw you in my dream, I saw you." And it was Montego Joe you know? Montego was one of those classic Caribbean percussionists, man, who had made it sort of on the big stage with guys like Babatunde Olatunji and, you know, Chief Bey, and you know, I mean it was that era, like the 50s, 60s, etcetera, and Montego was one of those musicians who had played, you know as a percussionist, he was a drummer, you know a set player, he played set and everything else. He toured with Hamiet Bluiett and all these guys and everything, and I'm sitting there with the guy. I don't know him, I don't know anything about him, I just know that I saw you in my dream, you're the one, don't move, don't say a word.

MR: How did he react to that?

C: He freaked out. He couldn't move. He was paralyzed. He was paralyzed. He was paralyzed. And of course, you know, I get on the phone after that and I called Emile and I said, "Emile, you wouldn't believe this." And I told Emile, I was like, I met two of the guys already. Because Frankie was one and Frankie took me under his wing. Frankie took me under his wing. And Frankie started teaching me. Frankie said, "Look, I want you to come up, this is where I teach up here. I think it will be much better for you to come up here, and I was with Frankie all the — now I was carrying Frank — now in those days, in the 80s, right, you had salsa nights at the Village Gate. Monday night at the Village Gate in New York City anybody who was studying percussion or interested in this feel had to be present there because that was school. That's where all the greats came through. Francisco Aguabella, Mongo Santamaria, Carlos Patato Valdez, Tito Puente, Celia Cruz, you know I mean all of the people, all of the people. Papo Pepin, I mean everybody came through there and played, and you had to be there. And Frankie used to work with all of them. So Frankie would give me his drum to carry so that I didn't have to pay, I would come in, you know, carrying Frankie's drum and Frankie playing with everybody. Man, listen, that was school. That was school. That's what I came through. And then he was up at Boy's Harbor, the same place like Chembo studied up at Boys's Harbor and everything else, same thing. Because that was the place where all of us were gathering information and taking an academic study of Latin percussion altogether.

MR: But that story about carrying someone else's drums, that mentorship, I'm really happy to hear that. Because fellows that were playing and learning in the 40s and in the 30s, that's what they did. Eddie Locke the drummer talked about carrying Joe Jones' drums or something.

C: Yeah, man.

MR: That was part of the school.

C: Yes, yes, yes. And I was fortunate. I mean guys don't do that these days you know. Everybody's on a different wavelength man. But for me, that was just an honor. It was an honor.

MR: How did you learn the vocal phrases and melodies that I heard yesterday? That sounds like a long, seems like a long-term —

C: Some of that was from Trinidad tradition. And lot of it is — and it's all Yoruba, right? So the tradition that, although there is Arara in Trinidad and there are Arara villages etcetera, this particular piece was Yoruba. And Trinidad was actually the patron saint of the island is Shango and the Shango "cult" quote unquote in Trinidad is a complete retention of the Yoruba presence, those divinities for the Africans who arrived in Trinidad. So I grew up with that stuff. My — I didn't know, but my mother's family was very, very close in the tradition. They were high priestesses in the tradition from my mother's side of the family. And when I started becoming aware, they were the ones who were guiding me. It was those ancestors, I can identify them, that were guiding me altogether. And you know I realized that my path was one in which I had to really do — my life was about a journey of self discovery through the people who had come before me, so that much later on in life I went and found my father's side of the family in Martinique, and in France and you know, I just started gathering information about who I was and where I came from. And I realized that, you know, the thing, it wasn't just a curiosity. It was the music that led me there. Because as I got into the percussion world there were certain flavors that just meant so much to me. Everything, you know, you inject this color into the music as a percussionist. But I didn't stay in one vein. I went into the Middle Eastern vein, I went into the North Indian and South Indian vein, I went into the Brazilian stuff. I went into the West African stuff. Yesterday I sat in on the West Africa class here and knew the pieces that they were playing: Agbekor and Gahu and everything else, vowed with Lydia to come back and you know, spend some time with the kids and everything else. Because I had studied that stuff. So I went into, I guess part of it is that I am the child of a confluence of global and traditional bloodlines. I am a product of the world, not of one group of people. I am a product of all kinds of bloodlines that have come together and the thing that helped me to discover that even more was the music. Because when I pick up a Middle Eastern tambourine and I play it, there's something that is speaking to me. When I go to frame drums and I play frame drums and I study and I connect with people from Istanbul and from Syria and stuff. Because my grandfather on my mother's side was Syrian-Lebanese. I never knew him. I never met him. But I remember distinctly when I discovered the percussive realm of the Middle East and Syria. I had — my grandfather came to me in a dream. And it didn't happen — it didn't happen until I had walked into that percussive realm.

MR: Well this goes back to what we were talking about when we started today, this, what is it that that percussion music brings out of you.

C: Correct.

MR: I guess you can really speak to that.

C: Yeah and this is what, I mean, this is how I interact in the music you know. I remember doing a concert recently and I hadn't brought out my conch horns in a long time. And I decided just to work with it and something just told me just to work with it. We were doing a concert with T.K. Blue called Motherland Connections, right? And when it came time for the solo, instead of doing a conga solo I just knew, something just guided, pick up the conch horn. And I did a solo on the conch horn. And that horn I remember as a little boy, my family would get away every summer and we would go spend some time on a beach that my mom and dad really, really loved called Mayaro, which is on the southeast coast of Trinidad, and we would rent a place and we would stay there for the whole summer. But the entire thing about that was that on the morning, early in the morning you would hear the conch horn blowing to call the fisherman to come to go out to fish. And then from the boat and from the land you would hear these conch horns going back and forth when the fisherman were coming back in because what they were doing is they were calling the villagers to come and help pull in the seine nets. Right? And so we would get up and we would go and we would be hauling in nets, and you know everybody is pulling seine and everything, and tons of fish coming in. I mean that was life. Later on as I grew up and I learned more, you know, that horn was actually a symbol of the freedom and the power and another level of communication among the maroon slaves, especially the maroons in the Coptic country of Jamaica. They called it abhang and they use the conch horn and another animal horn to signal if the infiltrators were coming close by and they would set up these calls all over to alert the other communities, the other maroon communities, the runaway slaves, you know, that the Spaniards or the British or the French or whoever, that they were coming, that people were coming. So I got up and I took this conch horn solo you know. And it just came out of my heart you know. And it was well received. I didn't expect it at all, I just went, you know, I just went with the moment. So this is what happens. There's a color. There's something in the music when you live that close to the earth you know, that it's not cerebral. It's not something that okay this is where this goes etcetera. It's in response to what's going on. It's in response to what's happening in the music. And I think for all these people that, all these guys man, all the guys who play this music and jazz and you know, the Brazilian jazz and the roots of jazz — when you sit down and you talk to them it's not their academic study that made them the musicians that they are. Yes it helped them, no doubt. But there are a lot of them that never even went to school and they

picked up, they got their chops on the street. They got their chops on the stage. They got their chops, you know, on the road you know? And it became something that they lived. It became something that gave them — that fed their spirit. Their body might have deteriorated but their spirit and their soul was being fed by something that we can't put our finger on.

MR: Exactly. And I have experienced that with people like, these photos we are looking at taken by Milt Hinton and that generation, somehow in talking to them and just sitting next to them you felt better afterwards, like they were passing on whatever it is that we can't nail down, but it is something that gets passed on.

C: And they live it. We live it. And I'm fortunate, I feel really really blessed at this stage in my life to be doing something like what we did yesterday in the performance and performing with other people etcetera, and being able to touch lives. You know I remember, you know, in Trinidad we had, part of the carnival culture was to have these huge brass bands on the road. And I had belonged to one of the big and really hot brass bands back in the 80s into the early 90s in Trinidad. And it shaped the lives of so many younger musicians. And it was sad to hear that, you know, they didn't have those brass bands, like the DJs took over and now they didn't want to pay musicians. They could have DJs and people making some noise and stuff, and you know everybody's going down the street and the bands just got wiped out completely. And it was — I was happy to hear a young musician saying recently that he is trying to revive this because his musicianship, his love for music, came from hearing these big brass bands on the road during carnival, and he wanted to play his trumpet. He wanted to be part of that section you know. And where we go today and where we play today, you have no idea of whose life you are going to touch and in what way you're going to touch that life. And that's a gift that we have been given. It's a gift that we have to nurture. It's a gift that we have to respect. It's a gift that we have to hold in the highest elevation because that is our purpose.

MR: Do you get aggravated if you're playing, you're thrown together with other percussionists or that are playing this music, and they don't treat it with the same respect or passion that you do?

C: I don't. Because I recognize that everybody is coming from a different place you know. There is tolerance and there is leading by example. And I've always believed that if your character and if your composure can speak for you in what it is you are doing then somehow or the other you're going to touch that life and people are going to remember and take something with you. And it doesn't matter what they take as long as they take something with you and it helps to transform their lives or their thinking or their thought down the road. "Okay. Take a piece of me." You know? Even if you're not a musician

and you come to a concert or something and you hear something that's really beautiful and in your deepest and darkest moment you remember that experience that caused you such elation at that point in time. Take a piece of it with you. Take it with you you know. Let it manifest, let it change your life. We are not here — we are the soldiers for peace and harmony and for a better world. When, I always remember, you know that poem if the rest of the world is losing their head and you can keep your head about you then yours is the world my son. And if, as we see in our environment today the way global leaders are treating people and speaking about their desire to not recognize the plight of others, I mean you know we are the ones that have to send that message out strongly because this is who we are. We are global citizens. Music doesn't belong to any one person you know. It's there for all. And there's no other language that brings people together like music. There's nothing. You know I've lived it myself that you know, where music has touched my soul or a performer has touched my soul and brought about this immense change in me, like Don Alias and Emile Latimer. I mean I will leave the planet with that in my heart, hoping that I will be able to see them in the next realm when I get there. Because I know Emile is waiting for me. I know — I did his memorial. I lived one of my greatest musical dreams being the percussionist for Jon Lucien. I mean Jon was one of the few guys from the Caribbean to like take the jazz world and in the late 70s into the 80s etcetera, I mean his music, Jon's music brought me through college, brought me through university, through my darkest time. Him, Lonnie Liston Smith, you know, and I just met Lonnie. I drove — I hadn't seen or heard from Lonnie in over thirty years. And I drove, I was looking up something and I came across Keystone Corner in Baltimore and I saw Lonnie Liston Smith. And I left the house, I jumped in the car and I drove four hours to Baltimore to see and meet one of the guys who I revered for his cosmic — he was my cosmic jazz master. You know? And listen, when he hugged me, you know I'm 62 now I mean to get a hug from one of your icons, and I was like — I don't know if you listen to music but I want you to know how much you influenced me etcetera etcetera. And I brought a CD of mine just so that you can hear. And I'm reaching into my jacket pocket to try and pull out the CD and I'm so nervous and I'm going to see him perform and I'm standing there with one of my cards, and he's helping me to pull the CD out of my shirt. And oh listen, and Jon Lucien was another guy like that man. Jon took me through university. I mean I listened to that guy [scats]. I mean listen, I fed off of that music and it was — I had — when I came to New York I searched for Jon left, right and center. He was nowhere to be found. He had stopped performing. He was in rehab. He was all over the world etcetera until a friend of mine many many years later said, "Hey Cascadu, I saw," because everybody knew that I was a Jon Lucien fanatic, right? "Hey Cascadu, I just saw a poster at LIU for Jon Lucien." I said, "What!" Okay it means he's got to be in

town. If you saw it, right, because it had passed already. He's got to be in town. And I looked up and I saw he was at the Blue Note. I hauled my butt down to the Blue Note that night man, and I went to the Blue Note, and I got there early, super early. I was one of the first people getting into the Blue Note. And Jon came onto the stage, this frail guy man. This frail guy. And I'm looking at him and I'm like this is the man, this is the moment I waited for and that band kicked off [scats] and his pipes came out, that soft, velvety, deep baritone man. And I was in seventh heaven. At the end of the show — I stayed for the second show and at the end of the show I was like, what do I do? I can't leave. I've got to connect with this guy. I've waited all these years, so many years have passed, over thirty years, to meet this guy. I'd never seen him. And I was scared. I didn't know what to do, how do I get up to the room to say hello? So I had a decision — you leave and you walk away from this just having seen your idol, or you go upstairs and you connect with him. And I got up — I walked up the stairs at the Blue Note man, and I got to the green room and the door was closed but I could hear all the musicians, there's all laughter and chatter and everything else going on. And I knocked on the door. And I heard, "Who go there?" And the door swings open. One of the musicians had — 'cause they're all sitting down in rows like this, right. So somebody opened the door this way and Jon is sitting in one of those big Indonesian rattan chairs, sitting like a king in the chair, all these musicians on the side here, and there's a pathway, a very narrow pathway leading straight to the door. I am at the door and Jon is sitting straight in front of me. And I said, when, you know, "Who go there" and the door opens, I said, "Mr. Lucien, I am your son!" I didn't know what else to say, because this man had fathered my music, he had fathered my heart, he had fathered my creativity. I listened to all his musicians, I played his records day in, day out man, anywhere I went I spoke about Jon Lucien, spoke about the beauty of his music, I mean this guy was like my life. You know? And all of a sudden, I didn't know what to say. I was scared. And I said, "Mr. Lucien my name is Cascadu. I'm your son." And Jon got up from the chair. He got up and there was a woman sitting right next to him who I later found out was his wife. He got up from the chair. The musicians in the room went dead silent. You could hear a rat piss on cotton in the far corner of the hall. Everybody was dead silent. Silence in the room. Jon got up. He looked at his wife like this, and he said, "Come my son." And I walked into Jon's arms. I was shaking. I walked into my idol's arms and he did not let me go. He held onto me like you would not believe man. And I just grabbed onto him. And there were no words coming out of my mouth at that point in time. The room was silent. All his big musicians were standing, sitting right there. His wife sitting right there. And we just, in this embrace, locked in this embrace. And there was nothing to tell me that this was anything other than one of the most divine moments of my life. I could feel like there was energy just coming down and bathing us

in that embrace. And he, after, he said, "So what you do my son?" I said, "Well I'm a musician, I'm a percussionist" etcetera. He says, "Well look," he gave me his card. He said "I'm going back to" he was living in Puerto Rico at the time and he says, "I'm going back in three days. Call me." I said okay. In three days I called Jon. From that day anytime Jon came to New York he would call me and I would go and pick him up at the airport. I would carry his guitar. I would carry his guitar. Through Jon, he and Herbie Hancock came off the plane together. I didn't know these guys were buddies. He, Wayne Shorter and Herbie Hancock were like this you know. And man, I carried Jon's guitar — when we were pregnant with our first child I remember being on the phone and I said to Jon I was like, "Jon" I said, "the only thing I really want to give that baby right now is the waves of the ocean." Jon says, "Come, come to Puerto Rico. Come and stay with us." So I packed my wife up, packed our bags and we went and stayed with Jon in Puerto Rico and it was there just with him playing the music and stuff, and me knocking around on a couple of instruments he had around the place. He says, "Man, I want you to start playing with me. Come and play with me my son." And that's — the rest was history. I was on the bandstand with Jon, recording with Jon, gigging with Jon, traveling with Jon, Jon appeared, a little cameo appearance on my CD on "Island Woman" you will hear him in the back of me [scats]. Ah. Just that he would breathe on my album was — and as a matter of fact I had stopped playing music altogether. And when I took my tape to Jon, you know I had a cassette tape and I had never done anything with what I had recorded. I took it to Jon and Jon said, "My son, but you have something here. You've got to do something with this" you know. And it was Jon who took me by the hand, Monk, by the hand, into the studio with my two inch, my two boxes of two inch analog tapes.

MR: I have three in my basement.

C: Because the technology had changed. Nobody was recording on analog anymore, you know the studios were all set up for digital, all I had were my two boxes with my, you know, and I'm hauling these boxes and stuff, and it was Jon who took me to the studio to take all of that stuff and dump it into digital form. And he oversee'd the process when I would go into the studio, I would come home, I would stay by him and, this is what I got and he would check it out for me. I mean you couldn't ask for any greater love man. And that's what I find with these musicians too. You know sometimes you think that you can't reach them, and these guys are like come, come, come, come learn, come study, come hang out, come, let's talk. And Jimmy Owens is one of those guys man. I mean Jimmy has mentored me in so many ways. And if it wasn't for Jimmy, you know I probably would not be out there playing the way I'm playing because when I finished, I was a school principal, I founded a school in Bedford Stuyvesant, the first charter school of the New York City Department of Education which I ran for like about sixteen years. And

when I was finished with that, and it almost took me out, I was really sick and everything, you know I called Jimmy and I said, "Jimmy," 'cause I always stayed in touch with Jimmy throughout the years. And I said, "Jimmy, I'm finished man. I'm tired of this thing. I'm not well you know, the school has taken me out, it's going to take me a while to recover and everything else." And Jimmy says, "Come in. Come let's go play music." And he put me on the bandstand right away. And I think that part of that is that Jimmy also knows how healing that music is. And he told me stories of so many of the guys man, like Lionel, who was so sick, but you put them in front of their instrument and something takes over. And for that moment, that hour, that time, that energy is so healing, it's so powerful. It keeps them alive. It keeps you young. It helps you to forget the pain. It helps you to forget your suffering. It helps you — you know you communicate with people and people give back you know. Whether it's in the applause or whether they come up to you and they say hello or they want to touch you or they want — you know they want something. It makes you feel, you know, like life is really worth living in spite of the suffering. And that's the human condition, right? We're not, you know, we're not separate from our suffering. Part of our life is we're going to go through hardships, whether it's physical or otherwise. But there's something that this music brings that helps you to overcome some of your deepest and darkest challenges altogether. And that has to live in the spirit. That has to live in the spirit.

MR: That was extremely eloquent, and I'm — I had eighteen questions to ask you, so this means you have to come back to Hamilton College for part two of our interview. I mean I just am fascinated just to listen to you talk and I'm reminded of I was able to do two sessions with Jon Hendricks and he has the same positive — he had the same positive vibe that you do, and I most appreciate you making me feel better today.

C: Let that spirituality be praised. That's a gift that we share.

MR: Right.

C: And as many people that can be part of it, that's what the mission is now, until the end of the day, whenever that is you know. So I would be happy to come back, and thanks for having me.

MR: All right.

C: Thank you so much. I appreciate it.